

STATEMENT OF RESEARCH

Katie Apker

PhD Candidate - Cornell University

Organizational Behavior - ILR School

I am a PhD candidate in Organizational Behavior at Cornell University's ILR School. My research examines the social dynamics of entrepreneurship, work, and gender inequality, with a focus on how digital platforms and emerging technologies reshape opportunities and outcomes. Specifically, I investigate new forms of work enabled by digital technology, the origins and consequences of gendered patterns in digital entrepreneurship, and the social dynamics driving these patterns.

Dissertation and Job Market Paper

My dissertation examines digital entrepreneurship from multiple angles, applying management, entrepreneurship, and sociological theory. Across three chapters, I investigate how algorithms shape gendered entrepreneurial evaluation outcomes on digital platforms, how entrepreneurial identity shapes digital founders' behaviors and outcomes, and how content creation within the creator economy constitutes a distinct new form of digital venture creation.

My job market paper, "Approval Without Amplification: Gender and Entrepreneurial Visibility on Algorithmically Mediated Platforms," investigates gender-based disparities in viewership on YouTube. My paper explores why gender gaps persist on digital content platforms despite the removal of the resource-holding gatekeepers traditionally attributed as the source of women's disadvantage in entrepreneurship through negative evaluation. Using data from over 9,000 U.S.-based YouTube channels and linguistic analysis of over 6 million audience comments, I find that women creators receive approximately a third fewer total views (a key performance indicator) than comparable men, despite achieving higher engagement rates. The puzzle is that audiences evaluate women more favorably, not less: women's channels receive comments that are substantially more positive in tone and contain significantly less profanity.

Supply-side differences explain only part of the gap: production characteristics account for about a third of the raw gap, and no single creator-controlled content surface (topics, titles, transcripts, thumbnails) explains more than roughly nine percent of what remains. The evidence instead points to a demand-side account, though not one of negative evaluation: in mediation analyses, comment language explains 87% of the remaining view gap, with comment tone as the main channel. I introduce the concept of a negativity bonus: gendered treatment norms appear to produce systematically different engagement patterns for men and women, and engagement-optimizing algorithms amplify high-arousal, negatively contentious commentary into visibility and reach for these platform entrepreneurs, while underweighting the warm, supportive engagement that women entrepreneurs tend to receive. My results suggest that more favorable audience evaluation may

produce worse visibility outcomes within algorithmically mediated spaces that tie negativity and virality. These findings point to a challenge for a core assumption in the gender and entrepreneurship literature and suggest the need to integrate algorithmic intermediaries into our understanding of how gendered evaluation becomes consequential for entrepreneurial outcomes. The manuscript draft is complete, I am editing it for journal submission, and the paper has been accepted for presentation at the 2026 Academy of Management meeting.

In another dissertation chapter, currently under review at *Administrative Science Quarterly*, I draw on 61 qualitative interviews with digital-era entrepreneurs to identify a novel “Individualist” founder type who organizes the venture around the founder’s own idealized self rather than an external market opportunity. I offer a process model of entrepreneurial self-enclosure: digital tools, cultural scripts of self-actualization, and post-organizational precarity together make it both possible and culturally encouraged to found a venture without necessarily first verifying that anyone will pay, with weak market signals interpreted as the price of freedom. Finally, a third dissertation chapter conceptualizes content creation within the creator economy as a distinct new form of digital venture creation: one in which the creator’s persona is often the product, an algorithm stands between the creator and the audience, and near-zero entry costs permit founding and scaling without traditional infrastructure. I develop a three-phase account of how these ventures are founded and scaled, from establishing a persona and discovering an audience, to monetizing audience support, to converting persona equity into firm equity, with a full draft planned for fall 2026.

Broader Research Program

In other collaborative projects, I examine how evaluative institutions reshape macro organizational behavior and entrepreneurship. In one project, currently under review at *Organization Science*, I examine how gender ideology and institutionally-promoted separate-spheres cultural beliefs can shape the decline of women’s entrepreneurship. In another, I study how government rhetoric & mandates trigger heterogeneous regulatory compliance among employers, with political ideology moderating the timing of firms’ responses. In a third, I investigate how corporate responsibility ratings catalyze shifts in board gender diversity norms. Across these projects (and others), the common thread is a focus on how social dynamics, whether evaluative, ideological, or institutional, shape experiences and success in work settings.

Future Research Agenda

My future research program continues to explore the questions at the center of my dissertation: how do digital platforms and social forces shape who participates in entrepreneurship, and with what consequences for various social groups? While my job market paper samples creators at a few discrete points in time, for future work I am building a larger longitudinal panel dataset of YouTube creators, using multiple sampling methodologies and ongoing daily collection as an affiliate of

YouTube's Research Program, extending the observation window both backward and forward in time and enabling cohort analyses and causal inference methods. As this dataset matures, it will allow me to examine questions about how platform policy changes, new technologies like AI, and shifting audience behaviors differentially affect creators by social category over time. Beyond digital platforms, I am exploring how family and school structures shape entrepreneurial entry, examining whether spousal overwork pushes individuals into self-employment as a flexibility strategy and how gendered patterns of overwork may contribute to differences in who enters entrepreneurship and in what form.

My research questions are grounded in firsthand experience: before entering academia, I founded, operated, and sold a digital marketing asset company, experiencing the platform dynamics and gendered market conditions that I now study empirically. My research is relevant to scholars interested in the social dimensions of entrepreneurship, technology, innovation, labor markets, and organizational theory.